

How to Write Song Lyrics for Beginners

All the structure, rhymes & writing tips you need to make great lyrics

Co-authored by Andrea Stolpe and **Bailey Bujnosek, BA**

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We all know great lyrics when we hear them, but what exactly makes them so great? How do you write your own song lyrics that convey your message and help people connect with your music? In this article, we break down the songwriting process step-by-step, from getting inspiration to crafting the perfect lyrics to pairing your lyrics with music. We even include expert advice from vocal therapist Amy Chapman MA, CCC-SLP and vocal coach Tanisha Hall. Once you know the basics, you'll be ready to write a song whenever inspiration strikes!

Top Tips for Writing Song Lyrics

Songwriter Andrea Stolpe suggests writing what you know: practice free-writing and turn what you wrote into lyrics. It's also a good idea to study the lyrics of existing songs to get a sense of rhyme, rhythm, and imagery. Find your writing style, practice rhyming, and aim to show, not tell in your lyrics.

Understanding Common Song Structures

1. Before writing, understand all the different parts of a song.

Parts will help you organize your song as you write. Your song can include all of them or none of them—it all depends on what you want to do. However, in order to understand how most songs are structured, you'll need to understand the parts.^[1] They include:

- **An Introduction** - this is the section at the beginning which leads into the song. Sometimes it might sound different from the rest of the song. It might be faster or slower, or it might not exist at all. Many songs do not have an introduction, so don't feel like you have to use it.^[2]
- **A Verse** - This is the main part of the song. It is usually between half and double the number of lines as the chorus, but it doesn't have to be. What gives away a section of a song as a verse is that the melody is the same, but the lyrics are different between the different verses.^[3]
- **A Pre-Chorus** - The pre-chorus is an optional part of the song that makes the listeners anticipate the chorus. It's usually shorter than a verse or chorus.^[4]
- **A Chorus** - The chorus is the part of the song that repeats without changing: both the lyrics and melody are unchanged or nearly unchanged. This is usually where you try to fit the catchiest part of your song (usually called the hook).^[5]
- **A Bridge** - The bridge is a part that exists in some songs but not all. Usually coming sometime after the second chorus, the bridge is a part of the song that sounds completely different than the rest of the song. It is usually short, just a line or two of lyrics, and will sometimes lead into a key change.^[6]

EXPERT TIP

TANISHA HALL
Vocal Coach

Make the bridge respond to the whole song. When it comes to lyrics, a bridge should present a question, answer a question, or further emphasize the point of your song. If the main idea of your song is "I'm so sad, my love is gone," the bridge could present the idea that "maybe being alone is what I need."

2. Start with an AABA structure if you're new to lyric writing.

The AABA structure is probably the most common structure of a song in modern popular music. In the study of song structures, A usually signifies a verse and B usually signifies a chorus. In other words, in this structure there's a first verse, second verse, chorus, and then a final verse. Experiment with this basic structure while lyric writing, before moving on to more complex ones.^[7]

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Getting Inspiration

1. Write all the time.

You should always start by just writing.^[8] Write about your feelings. Write about the world around you. Describe a person or a thing that matters to you. This is to help you find the words most worthy of a song. Remember: it doesn't have to always be depressing or angry. Or even have an emotion. A laundry list could be song-worthy if done right.

- Journal entries can be a big inspiration for a song. For instance, when you're going through hard times, you might write song lyrics that encapsulate your frustration, despair, or hope. This will help your listeners relate to you.
- You're probably going to get writer's block—it happens to everyone. The best way to get past writer's block is to just get words down on paper. Don't worry if they're good or not.

2. Use a stream of consciousness exercise.

Stream of consciousness writing is where you just write and keep writing and don't stop: just write everything that comes into your head. Hall calls this “The Download.”^[9] While you might not use most of your ideas, this method can help you find a starting point for your lyrics when you're really lost.

- Do your exercise every day to help you brainstorm. Even if you don't like most of what you like, a vision may appear over time.

3. Study the lyrics of existing songs.

Look at popular songs which are known for great lyrics to get inspiration. Additionally, study your favorite songs. Consider why you like them. Look at the kinds of things they talk about, how they talk about them, what rhymes they use, the rhythm of the lyrics, the structure, etc.

- What you consider to be a good song might differ from someone else's preferences. Focus more on what you like, because that's the kind of music you'll most enjoy making.
- As a practice exercise, try writing different lyrics for a song you like. You might change a few lines or create a totally new version. Just don't try to pass a barely changed version off as your own.
- Look up the songwriters who penned your favorite songs. Check out their body of work to look for trends and to evaluate their style.

4. Be true to your style.

Don't feel pressured to write songs like someone else because everyone has a different style. It's totally okay to take a different approach to songwriting! Some write freely from their mind's eye, while others write with a specific intention. While there are lots of rules and conventions to music, at the end of the day, it's a creative venture. The most important thing is that it expresses *you*.

- Songwriting is an art-form, so it's good to develop your own style. Don't feel like you need to do what everyone else is doing.



Taylor Swift, Singer-Songwriter

Be brave when making music. "Songs are my diaries; they always have been. You have to put your trust in everyone because putting down those real, personal details and thoughts that make a song authentic also opens you right up."

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Finding Your Words

1. Show, don't tell.

If you simply state what you feel or what you're writing about, your song will be forgettable. The best lyrics, like any good writing, get us to feel emotions because they capture that experience—not because they tell us what to feel. Try to write about what it's like to feel something, instead of just telling your audience.

- An example of an alternative to writing "I'm so sad" is from Damien Rice's song *The Animals Were Gone*: "At night I dream without you, and hope I don't wake up; 'Cause waking up without you is like drinking from an empty cup."
 - The second line here uses a simile to compare waking up alone to drinking from an empty cup, a powerful symbol that suggests an unsatisfied desire.

2. Try to rhyme within reason.

Avoid having all of your lines rhyme, and work on making the rhymes that you do use look natural. Don't put weird phrases or words into your lyrics just to get a rhyme. Common rhyme schemes include AABB (rhyming couplets), ABAB (alternate rhyme), or AAAA (monorhyme).^[10]

- Good: "You make me feel real again/You just have to smile and I know/The sun's coming out - Amen!"

- Bad: "I really love my cat/My cat is where it's at/Her tail looks like a bat/She's getting kind of fat..."
- Ultimately, your lyrics don't have to rhyme. Plenty of songs have non-rhyming lyrics.
 - Of course, there are some genre considerations. Rap often has far more rhyming than other genres, but even then it's not required. It's just stylistic.

3. Organize the rhythm of your lines.

In songwriting, rhythm comes from the pattern of stressed (S) and unstressed (U) syllables in each line. A jumbled pattern (like S-U-U-S-S-U) will sound uneven, while an organized pattern (like S-U-S-U-S-U) will flow nicely. If you're unsure how to tell stressed and unstressed syllables apart in a word, say them aloud. Any syllable you put emphasis on is stressed.^[11]

- Some dictionaries put stressed syllables in bold when offering the pronunciation of a word. Use this to help you determine your rhythm. Alternatively, use an online stress-finding tool.
- One-syllable words are usually stressed, but not always.

4. Avoid cliches.

Cliches are phrases or rhymes that are overused and tired—they keep your songs from standing out and don't show off your unique talent. Example cliches are someone down on their knees (especially if they're begging please), someone walking down the street, or someone comparing being in love to flying. Challenge yourself to find new ways of conveying ideas and emotions in your lyrics.

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Putting Your Lyrics to Music

1. Understand music notation.

Learn about how music notation works (bars, measures, notes, rests, etc.) so that you can make sure your lyrics fit in with the music. Make sure your lines have a roughly even number of syllables and that your rhythm stays steady—don't speed up too much to fit in extra words.^[12]

- Think of a section of music as being like four cups of water. You can pour half of one of the cups into a fifth cup, but now you have two half-full cups. The first doesn't get any more water in it. Similarly, you can't add extra beats without making it up somewhere (usually, with a pause).

2. Start with a melody already written.

When you first start songwriting, it's best to start with a melody already written. This is easier for most people than trying to create a melody which matches existing lyrics. You can write your own melody, work with a musically gifted friend, or you can adapt a classical melody, such as from old folk songs (just be sure to only use songs in the public domain).

3. Stay in a range of about two octaves.

Anywhere above two octaves is a great vocal range, says Chapman.^[13] But not everyone has Mariah Carey's voice—most people will be comfortable within two octaves.^[14] When you come up with a melody, keep the notes within a reasonable range so that someone can actually sing it. Avoid anything larger than two octaves unless you know the person you're writing for can sing those notes.

- If you're writing the song for yourself, you'll need to find your own vocal range. Chapman explains how to do it:^[15]
 - First, warm up your voice, then hum and drop your voice down as low as you can go. The lowest you can go while still humming clearly is the bottom of the range.
 - Then, go as high as you can go. Wherever you can hold a note for 3 seconds, that's the top of your range.
- If you'd like to improve your vocal range, Chapman suggests you repeat the above exercise, but try to stretch your voice a little further each time you do so.^[16]

4. Add in places for the singer to take a breath.

Singers are human too, and they need to breathe. Put an extra two to four beats here and there that allow the singer to stop for a second and catch their breath. This also gives the listener a chance to take in what you are saying.^[17]

- A good example of this is the USA's national anthem. After the line "For the land of the free," there is a pause before "And the home of the brave," which allows the singer to recover from the very powerful previous few bars.

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Revising Lyrics

1. Read what you wrote.

Ask yourself: What is the bigger picture? Does the song form a coherent narrative? Are you showing instead of telling? Do you feel like it has a consistent rhythm? Think about what you want to say and how it comes across. It's rare to get a song exactly right the first time you write the lyrics.

- Other questions to ask yourself: Do you like the placement of the vowel and consonant sounds? Does a line have multiple meanings? Does a particular phrase stand out? Do you want to repeat a line or word?

2. Rewrite.

Who says you can't change what you have written? If you like the original, then keep it. But most lyricists need to play with the song a bit to get that perfect sound. Swap words or lines for better ones. If you move around entire verses, make sure the song has continuity. Sometimes, a song takes on a whole new meaning after revision.

- Try to perfect the first line so you hook the listener right away.
- Revising your song is the best way to write better lyrics. Many writers believe great writing is rewriting.

3. Consult with others.

Once you're done with your song, share a test version with others. Even if they're just reading your lyrics, they may be able to find places where the rhythm is off or where the rhymes sound strange. Of course, writing music by committee is a bad idea. But if they catch something and you agree that it's wrong, fix it!^[18]

4. Share your song.

We make the world a better place when we share the things that we create. It's okay to be shy. Just because you wrote a song doesn't mean that you have to go out and do a concert. But you should write it down or record it in such a way that you can share it with others on a platform like TikTok, YouTube, or SoundCloud.

- If you get negative comments, take them with a grain of salt. Everyone has to start somewhere. The important thing is that you keep writing lyrics and pushing yourself to improve.

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Join the Discussion...

How do I write good lyrics?

**Layla Faul**

I used to make songs a while ago and I wanna get back into that, but whenever I try to write lyrics my mind just goes blank. What should I do?

Read More**Andrea Stolpe****Songwriting Instructor and Artist Development Coach**

I think one of the top tips, and it comes across a bit cliché, but is to **write what you know**.

Read More**Carolyn Marie****Singer-Songwriter**

The best thing is to just rip the Band-Aid off and pick up your guitar and just get in there and start. **Starting is the most important thing** because if you never start, you never create anything. Songwriters and

Read More**See all 6 Replies and****Read Discussion**

Expert Q&A

Question

How can I be sure I'm writing my song in a good vocal range?

Amy Chapman, MA
Voice & Speech Coach
Expert Answer

Try to keep it within 2 octaves. If you're trying to find your own vocal range, hum down to the lowest note you can hold clearly. Then, hum up to find the highest note you can hold for at least 3 seconds. This will be your range.

Question

Is it necessary to have a verse and then a chorus in order in a song?

Community Answer

It doesn't matter what order you put them in, as long as the song makes sense and flows well.

Question

How can I get some proper ideas for the lyrics?

Community Answer

Think about your day, your emotions, the conversations you heard etc. Use them and you'll find yourself with an amazing song! If you cannot think of one, then think about your dreams, ambitions, inspirations, aspirations, etc. especially the ones that first convinced you to write song lyrics.

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Tips

- Think about who you want to hear your song. What is it that you want them to hear?
- It's good to have a song writing notebook or even use the Notes app on your phone. This helps you organize your thoughts better.
- Never dismiss an idea for a song as "too stupid". Many great songs are about outlandish topics.

Tips from our Readers

- Check out songs you love and study how the lyrics work. Try out different writing techniques until you land on a style that clicks. When I first started, I had no knowledge of song structure. Then I realized my favorite band used a specific song structure, so I tried that and progressed way faster.

Play with writing all kinds of songs to stretch your skills. Audiences like variety.

- Nail down the lyrics if you'll sing your songs live on stage. Before a show, have someone check to make sure the words make sense. If you blank on the lines, take a breath and go through them slowly. Rereading a few times can help them stick. This will give you confidence to belt out those lyrics.
- When first writing songs, you might copy classic tunes too much. While you can take cues from favorite songs, put your own spin on things. Most artists don't like direct copies. Instead, channel the vibe or style you admire, then create your own melodies and lyrics.
- Don't filter your real feelings when you write lyrics. Grab a pen and paper and let it all out — get to know yourself better in the process! The page won't tell your secrets or judge you, so share freely. Use this as therapy for your mind and heart.
- Craft lyrics that feel true to who you are. Songs come off more real when the words ring true to your identity. If certain lines seem untrue to your personality, they could be tough to perform with conviction.
- Keep a notebook on you to jot down song ideas when they hit. Inspiration can strike anywhere, anytime, so be ready to follow those creative sparks. Revisit your notes later when you're working on new material.

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Warnings

- Don't plagiarize a song somebody else wrote or you could get in some serious legal trouble. But it's good to pick a style of lyrics or music you like. So if you like Katy Perry, write pop like her. Or if you like Taylor Swift, write lots of love songs.
- Do not rhyme constantly, unless that is exactly what you intended. It is okay at some point, but too much gets annoying.

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